

SANGUIE ECHOES

High Concept Document

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*Cut through three cursed lands.
Every wound is a debt you can collect.*

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1 High Concept

1.1 High Concept Statement

Sanguine Echoes is a 2D gothic hack-and-slash roguelite in which the Ashen Hunter — an undead swordswoman bound to a blood-drinking blade — carves through three cursed lands on a single night-long hunt. Every wound she takes is a debt she can collect: land a hit, and the blood she lost returns to her.

1.2 Design Goal

Players should feel like a relentless, masterful hunter — rewarded for aggression, punished only for recklessness. The heart of that feeling is Sanguine Rally: damage converts part of your lost HP into a temporary rally pool, and landed melee hits convert it back into real health. Attacking is healing; retreating wastes recoverable life. On top of that core sits frame-accurate hitboxes, poise-break execution windows, hit-stop on every landed blow, and a 200 ms parry window — all tuned to a rhythm of read, counter, execute, so skilled play reads as flow rather than math.

1.3 Game Objective

This project is built as a portfolio showcase of end-to-end game-development craft. Its objectives are:

- To demonstrate mastery of Phaser 4's modern render-node architecture and strict TypeScript on a complete, shippable game.
- To prove design depth beyond a feature list — a cohesive combat identity (Sanguine Rally, poise and stagger, frame-accurate hitboxes) and a roguelite loop that keeps replays fresh.
- To deliver polished presentation — parallax gothic environments, a screen-anchored boss bar, juicy hit feedback, and full audio — so the result reads as a finished product, not a tech demo.

1.4 Gameplay

The player guides the Ashen Hunter through three handcrafted levels — the Gallows Graveyard (tutorial), the Haunted Forest, and Night Town — each a 2D action-platformer gauntlet of enemies that culminates in a boss fight.

Combat verbs: run, jump with one air re-jump, dash (stamina-gated), a quick-combo attack, hold-to-charge heavy, plunging dive, and a parry with counter. Deeper systems sit underneath: hitboxes that only connect on real impact frames; poise that chips under attacks until it breaks, opening a 3.5-second execution window; Sanguine Rally recovery; and localized hit-stop that gives every landed blow weight.

Control	Action
Left / Right or A / D	Move
Space / Up or W	Jump (one air re-jump)
L	Dash (ground + air, stamina-gated)
J	Attack / hold to charge / Down + J plunge
K	Parry (200 ms window)
U	Ultimate Surge (when charged)

Control	Action
E	Interact (reclaim echoes, open chests)
ESC	Pause

Roguelite loop: fallen enemies and exploration award Eldritch Echoes, a permanent meta-currency spent in the Sanctuary on a six-branch upgrade tree (Vitality, Strength, Reach, Riposte, Endurance, Swiftess). After each boss the player picks one of three Blood Gems — temporary run buffs such as +20% attack or +8% crit. Clearing the final boss ends the run in victory.

1.5 Story and Setting

The world is a dying gothic realm strangled by a blood-curse called the Echoes, which stirs the dead and twists the living into beasts. Three regions have already fallen: the Gallows Graveyard, where the hanged twitch again; the Haunted Forest, where hollow knights and witch-wizards enforce an oath to a forgotten queen; and Night Town, a city that has not seen dawn since the Arch-Demon took its spires.

The Ashen Hunter is a revenant — a woman returned to the world by the blade she wields, which drinks the blood of the fallen. She walks the three lands to cut down the Hell Beast, the Hollow Wyrms, and finally the Arch-Demon itself. Each drop of blood she reclaims echoes back a fragment of the person she used to be; the Echoes she hoards are both her currency and her memory. When the final demon falls and the curse breaks, she chooses whether to fade or to rise.

1.6 Features

- Fluid 2D action-platformer movement: run, jump with air re-jump, dash, plunge.
- Layered melee combat: quick combo, charged heavy, plunge, parry with counter.
- Frame-accurate hitboxes — attacks connect only on genuine impact frames.
- Poise and stagger with execution windows, plus enemy super-armor phases.
- Sanguine Rally — aggression-based health recovery.
- Localized hit-stop and slow-motion combat feedback.
- A distinct enemy roster per level: vampires, jumping demons, flying eyes, armored knights, spellcasters, mutant toads, werewolves, and ghost casters.
- Multi-phase bosses with telegraphed attacks (Hell Beast, Hollow Wyrms, Arch-Demon).
- Roguelite meta-progression: Eldritch Echoes and a six-branch permanent upgrade tree.
- Run-buff system: a Blood Gem choice after every boss.
- Three parallax gothic environments with composed floor props.
- Full UI suite: dual health/rally bar, dash stamina, screen-anchored boss bar, floating combat numbers, tutorial prompts, and a pause menu.
- Complete audio: SFX and music through a dedicated sound manager.

1.7 Unique Selling Point

- Sanguine Rally — damage converts part of every hit you take into a temporary pool that only landed melee hits restore. It inverts the “back off to heal” reflex: aggression is literally recovery.

- Poise as rhythm — no enemy is a damage sponge. Poise chips under your attacks and, when broken, opens a 3.5-second execution window; bosses then enter super-armor. Duels become an ebb-and-flow cadence instead of a stat check.
- Frame-true lethality — both weapon hitboxes and body-contact damage are gated to specific animation frames, so every kill is earned by reading timing rather than mashing.
- Two dodge philosophies — the ground dash grants blanket invincibility frames, while the air dash is a positional dodge with only a sliver of protection, forcing a real choice about when to commit.
- Localized hit-stop — slow-motion affects only the player and the exact target, never bystanders or projectiles, so impact reads loudly without breaking the fight.

1.8 Genre

2D action-platformer × hack-and-slash × roguelite — a gothic action-roguelite with a Souls-like duel cadence wrapped in pixel-art dark fantasy.

1.9 Target Audience

- Core action players who enjoy mastery-driven combat (fans of Dead Cells, Hades, Hollow Knight, Salt and Sanctuary, and Souls-likes).
- Roguelite players drawn to meta-progression and build variety (Blood Gems, the upgrade tree).
- Fans of gothic and dark-fantasy aesthetics and crisp pixel art.
- Ages 13+ — stylized fantasy violence without gore.
- Browser-playable, so anyone on a desktop PC can try it with a single click.

1.10 Target Hardware

Primary: desktop web browsers on PC and laptop (Chrome, Edge, Firefox). The game is a Phaser 4 + Vite web build, keyboard-driven (arrows/WASD with J, K, L, E), rendered to a 16:9 canvas. It runs at a stable 60 fps on mid-range hardware and needs no installation — it can be deployed to itch.io, GitHub Pages, or any static host.

2 Development Stack and Tools

Layer	Choice
Engine	Phaser 4 (render-node architecture)
Language	TypeScript (strict)
Tooling	Vite (build + HMR dev server)
Physics	Arcade Physics (kinematic movement)
Art	Ansimuz Legacy Collection (CCo); spritesheets rebuilt with Python tools
Audio	Free-to-use SFX and music packs

3 Credits

- Engine: Phaser 4

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- Audio: Mini Fantasy Dungeon (Leohpaz), 400 Sounds Pack (Chequered Ink), Universal UI SFX (Candle Light), RPG Essentials SFX (Leohpaz)